



GEGA2007-001 Empires and Overseas

Assignment 2 -VOICES-OF-THE-VANQUISHED design report

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Game Introduction:

It is set against the background of the actual historical invasion of the American continent by the Spanish during the 16th century.

Students play the roles of four different fictional historical personas, through which they explore the events surrounding the Spanish conquest and colonization of the Americas. Their characters are beset by the aggression of Spanish soldiers and an even more deadly threat: smallpox and other Old World diseases.

Each of the characters in the game will provide three different choices, all inspired by real historical developments; the players will decide their ultimate fate. Players will embark on a journey that fully submerges them in the historical and cultural context of the time.

The Four Characters

Popoca: an Aztec feather worker and witness to the tragic Fall of Tenochtitlan.

Kallpa: An Andean highlander, a herdsman, who has survived the fall of the Inca Empire.

Guani: A Taíno agronomist who must face the invasion of the Spanish colonizers.

B'alam-a Maya trader fighting for survival and identity between the Old and New Worlds.

Game Inspiration: The Great Divergence

This game is inspired by my observation of the striking differences between the pandemic response policies of many regions when the COVID-19 outbreak happened. Policymakers in different countries and territories had very different approaches to the pandemic.

For instance, Macau has mostly kept a policy in line with the rigid anti-pandemic measures of mainland China, while it was only toward the end of 2022 that it switched formally to a "living with the virus" policy. In contrast, nearby Hong Kong, though initially putting in place strict controls similar to the mainland, found it impossible to maintain "Dynamic Zero-COVID" following a massive outbreak.

"One Disaster, A Thousand Lives"

My friends and relatives were scattered across these different regions, and their personal experiences of these varied policies were vastly different; some endured long lockdowns, while others returned to normal relatively quickly. This striking contrast-"One disaster, a thousand lives"-deeply moved me.

It led me to reflect upon the question: What if this idea of "a single huge upheaval following which different groups take entirely different paths" were placed within a historical perspective?

The 16th Century Parallel

I instantly thought of the Spanish invasion of the Americas. That historical event also had the same catastrophic elements of an infectious disease, such as smallpox, with foreign conquest. In scale and destructiveness, the impact of smallpox on indigenous American societies could be compared to a modern-day global pandemic.

The objective of this game, therefore, will be the simulation of divergent paths of survival or destruction taken under the dual shock of 16th-century Spanish invasion and disease outbreak by various empires, city-states, and families such as the Aztec, Inca, and the Maya's Xiu and Cocom factions.

These different fates would be decided by factors such as geographical location, political choices, cultural beliefs, and alliances with the outside world. Each thread attempts to represent the struggle, adaptation, and tough decisions ordinary people make while living through a historical moment-as we all went through during this last pandemic.

Character Analysis: Popoca

The Amanteca (Feather Worker) Popoca's story is built upon a very profound understanding of Aztec social stratification and historical upheaval occasioned by the conquest. His profession as an Amanteca, or Feather Worker, defined the high status that he enjoyed in society, but it also would become the linchpin when the plague and invasion finally shook his faith and pride.

I. The Foundation: The Pride of an Elite Artisan

The Amanteca held a very high status in Aztec society; this was not a profession available to the commoners (macehualli). They had to undergo very extended and specialized training, were considered elite artists in service to the Emperor (Tlatoani), the nobility, and the temples. Their work involved expensive feathers, especially the long tail feathers of the Quetzal bird, obtained as tribute throughout the empire. Aztecs believed that these bright feathers were sacred, infused with cosmic power. Therefore, the work of the Amanteca was considered ritual communication with the gods.

As a result, Popoca is intensely professional and profoundly arrogant. As part of the established order, he naturally wanted his son, Coyotl to inherit this prestige. His behavior with the commoner and with his son in Act I demonstrates this aristocratic superiority and his view that the social order ought to be as immovable as the gods in the heavens and the Emperor in the palace

II. The Crisis: The Shaking of Faith

When the Smallpox (Huey Cocoliztli) epidemic broke out and his wife Xiloxoch and son Coyotl died, Popoca's foundational conviction was dealt a lethal blow. His impassioned pleas to the gods he worshipped, including Xiuhtecuhtli, the Lord of Craft, went unheard. This situation made him reevaluate the pride and faith that defined his life. It was when he realized the hands "that once made feathers fly" could not stop the pustules or break the fever that his personal pride fell along with the established world order.

III. Choices and Historical Fates

Popoca's three choices accurately represent the three main historical fates that befell the Aztec elite and professional during and immediately after the Fall of Tenochtitlan.

Option 1: Metamorphosis The Warrior's Death Heroic Annihilation

Historical Context: The Aztec Empire was one of few that glorified death in battle. In the final siege in 1521, social lines were blurred as many citizens who were not warriors joined in the ultimate resistance.

Character Motivation: Having lost everything, Popoca sheds his Amanteca identity to die as a Tenochca. Without having been trained for combat, this is his last act of personal and national dignity, the purest, most tragic form of resistance against the

tide of history.

Choice 2: Flight (The Survivor Noble) – Cultural Continuity

Historical Background: Traditionally, many of the Aztec nobles were successfully able to escape the besieged capital and flee into regional neighbors such as those residing near Tlacopan.

Character Motivation: He chooses survival to remember his family and lost civilization.

These survivors often provided the basis for new Indigenous communities after the war and, therefore, ensured the continuity of the Nahuatl culture and language. During Spanish rule, they adapted to perform important functions among the local elite—that is to say, as Indigenous nobles, caciques.

Choice 3: Survival (The Colonial Artisan) – The Alienation of Craft

Historical Context: During the early colonial period, Franciscan friars recognized the value of the highly skilled Aztec artisans. They actively recruited and utilized surviving Amanteca.

Character Motivation: While his soul is dead, his instinct for physical survival, combined with his highly valuable and unique skills, get "recycled" by the new regime. Post-Conquest Impact: Popoca crafting a cloak for the Virgin Mary was one example of the famous Colonial Feather Art (Arte Plumario). Such an artistic fusion indicates how the skills of the best Aztec artisans were alienated from their original purpose, forced to serve colonial rule and the Christian faith.

Character Comparison: Popoca and Reiner Braun

Popoca's character draws inspiration directly from Reiner Braun in Attack on Titan. The similarity between them lies in the common path of elite entrenchment into an ideological system, followed by a catastrophic collapse that brought about heavy mental trauma and tough choices.

I. Common Foundation: Elite Status and Indoctrination

Both characters enjoyed a degree of privileged status derived from their roles within a rigid social hierarchy and were endowed with a particular ideology:

Popoca (Aztec Amanteca): As a Feather Worker, his status was held in high regard and made him socially stable and privileged. He was taught that his craft served the gods and maintained the cosmic order of the Aztecs.

Reiner was a Marleyan Warrior and the holder of the Armored Titan, meaning he had a comparably high status within the military of Marley, including honorary citizenship

for his family. He had been indoctrinated to believe that Eldians on Paradis Island were "Devils" and deserved destruction.

They took pride in the security of their social standing and the rightfulness of their assigned tasks.

II. The Mechanism of Psychological Collapse

The collapse of their faith came when deeply held ideologies clashed with undeniable reality.

Disillusionment of Popoca: He watched his gods and his sacred craft, which were unable to stem the smallpox plague that took his wife and son, and then saw the total destruction of his stable empire. He began to realize that the divine order he served was fragile and unreliable.

Reiner's Disillusionment: His faith shattered when he lived among the Eldians on Paradis. He gradually came to understand that they were ordinary people, much like him, which directly opposed the "Devils" doctrine he had grown up with. He knew he had contributed to the brutal devastation of innocent life and happiness.

This psychological chasm led both to severe internal breakdown: in Reiner, this presented as severe dissociative identity disorder, whereby he could no longer differentiate between his personality as a "Marleyan Warrior" from his fictional self as a "Wall Soldier."

III. Thematic Correspondence in Final Choices

Popoca's three ultimate choices mirror the complex fates and psychological responses of the Marleyan Warriors facing their broken mission.

Option 1: Metamorphosis (The Warrior's Death)

AoT Parallel: This is the fate of Bertholdt Hoover or the sacrifice of Marcel Galliard.

Interpretation: It is a final tragic act of self-immolation or pure sacrifice. For the first time, Popoca picks up a weapon, dying for the last vestiges of a pure ideal-or an act of final atonement-serving as a noble, albeit self-destructive, defense of his final dignity.

Choice 2: To escape, the survivor

AoT Parallel: This also corresponds to how Reiner has continuously tried to abandon the mission to return to Marley for survival and reunion with family.

Interpretation: Popoca gives up his great mission and decides to survive with his painful memories, turning into an outcast in the new order. His goal is simple and

secular: survival.

Choice 3: Survival (The Alienated Servant)

AoT Parallel: This parallels Zeke Yeager's strategy or the Warriors' need to take on the mantle of "Wall Soldiers" during their infiltration. This is a corrupt, twisted adaptation to the new system. Just like Popoca uses his Aztec craft to serve the Virgin Mary and the Spanish Church, Reiner and the Warriors assume a false identity to dupe and survive within the walls of the enemy. Indeed, this would be the ultimate act of treason and alienation against one's former self and belief system.



The character of Popoca is primarily informed by the Florentine Codex (Sahagún, 1577), especially its ethnographic accounts of the *amanteca* (featherworkers) in Book 9 and the indigenous narrative of the conquest in Book 12. The Codex provides direct evidence for the high status of feather artisans, the spiritual significance of quetzal feathers, and the threefold post-conquest trajectories of survival, resistance, and adaptation.

Character Analysis: Kallpa, the Andean Highlander

Kallpa's character arc is demarcated by his profound loyalty to the Andean communal system and the tragic collapse of the Inca Imperial ideology he has been taught to believe upholds that system. His journey runs from absolute faith in cosmic balance to profound personal disillusionment and secular survival.

I. Foundational Beliefs and Context

Kallpa is set as a young herder, whose life revolves around the Ayllu—the basic unit of Inca extended kinship and community—in the Andean highlands.

The core principle (Ayni) that orders his life is the sacred contract that involves people working together, tending terraces, and restoring cosmic balance to ensure that the Sun (Inti) rises and the Earth (Pachamama) harvests.

Theocratic Loyalty: Kallpa viewed the Sapa Inca, or the supreme ruler, as the Son of the Sun, and he was a vital component in maintaining cosmic order.

In sharp contrast, the Inca Empire was not an immediate, overriding presence in his daily life but an abstract entity passed on through oral tradition. The real tangible anchor was his kin, especially his cousin Pacha, who embodied the Ayni principle.

II. The Progressive Collapse of Faith

The belief system of Kallpa disintegrated in a series of escalating betrayals in which the personal superseded the abstract:

Initial Doubt-The Mit'a: The conscription of his cousin Pacha for the national labor system, the Mit'a, was the first unsettling event which already challenged his understanding of the demands of the empire.

The first among them was the Divine Betrayal or Smallpox, which is considered a lethal blow and the death of the supreme ruler Sapa Inca Huayna Capac due to the smallpox plague. This forced Kallpa to question whether the "Son of the Sun," if he could not protect his own life, was truly maintaining the cosmic law.

The Personal Betrayal (Civil War): The following civil war between the royal heirs split the Ayllu into warring factions—their own people at war against them, literally represented by Pacha being forced into the enemy's army. This direct, localized experience of Ayllu self-cannibalization was a far greater blow than the Sapa Inca's death. It proved the Imperial system was not only failing but actively destroying the sacred principle of Ayni itself.

The Final Confirmation (Execution): The execution of the victorious Sapa Inca, Atahualpa, by the Spanish—followed by the sun rising the next day—simply confirmed Kallpa's growing suspicion: the entire divine kingship was a false religious construct. His personal sacrifice and Pacha's Mit'a were for naught.

III. Historical Fates and Personal Choices

Kallpa's three options stem from the documented reality of Andean survival during the early colonial era:

Choice 1: Submission (Mine Labor)

Historical Basis: The Spanish enslaved enormous numbers of Indigenous Andeans to work in silver mines—for instance, Potosí. This system, a brutalization of the Inca Mit'a, exposed workers to high risks of mercury poisoning and cave-ins.

Kallpa's Motive: It is that last desperate act of defiance directed at the false gods. His final thought, "not having to see the deceiving sun tomorrow," was a final, desperate revenge against the cosmic system that had betrayed him.

Option 2: Resistance (Fighting for the Ayllu)

Historical Basis: Discontented with the leadership of the Imperial Inca yet refusing to surrender to the Spanish, many indigenous peoples joined the protracted resistance led by figures such as Manco Inca in the Neo-Inca State of Vilcabamba.

Kallpa's Motivation: His allegiance shifts entirely from the defunct Empire to the Ayllu, that is, his family. The root of his belief shrinks to the very fundamental instinct for the survival of his wife and child. He does not fight for an invisible god but for the living ones.

Option 3: Adaptation (Estate Foreman) Historical Basis: This reflects the dark reality of survival wherein some indigenous leaders or skilled workers compromised and collaborated with the Spanish Encomenderos or estate owners for protection or a rise in status. Kallpa's Motivation: He wants to save his Ayllu from the very worst kinds of slavery, but he pays the ultimate price by becoming a traitor to Ayni through the oppression of his own people. The final irony lies in how the "safety" he bought at the cost of his moral corruption becomes futile when the diseases he sought to escape finally catch up with his protected family in the estate environment, crowded as it is, demonstrating the futility of his compromise.

Character Comparison: Kallpa and Levi Ackerman

Kallpa's character arc is similar to that of Levi Ackerman in Attack on Titan. The essential similarity between the two characters is that both are diligent

executioners who come from the margins, yet their actions progressively place them in crisis after crisis that undermines their foundational beliefs and the integrity of the systems they serve.

The Three-Stage Erosion of Faith

The disillusionment of both characters unfolds in three corresponding stages, wherein a series of external impacts dismantled the internal convictions:

Stage 1: The Sacrifice of Questioning

Levi's Crisis: During the early missions of the Survey Corps, Levi slowly started to question if the noble sacrifice of his many comrades was really justified by the "great ideals" which the mission presumably stood for.

Kallpa's Parallel: Kallpa first began questioning the system when his cousin, Pacha, was conscripted for the Mit'a, or Imperial labor duty. This early example of obligatory service already had him question what the cost of the Imperial system was to his immediate, beloved community.

Stage 2: Betrayal by the Ruling Authority

Levi's Crisis: While the internal power struggle was going on behind the walls, Levi found out that the Central Military Police and the Royal Family were lying and planning the murder of the Survey Corps. At this point, Levi lost all his trust in the system and decided on a coup d'état.

Kallpa's parallel to this is the crisis he suffered when the Inca Civil War broke up the Ayllu—that is, his community. He realized that the Imperial system, which was supposed to guarantee cosmic order, was instead actively destroying the sacred principle of Ayni through its internal self-destruction. The event led him to discard his faith in the "Son of the Sun" and the Imperial order.

Stage 3: Sacrifice of Personal Loyalty to the Future

Crisis of Levi: Ultimately, Levi had to decide either to save Erwin, his only trusted leader and anchor of his past loyalty, or to save Armin, the representation of humanity's future hope. His choice symbolized the final act of abandoning personal commitment for the future and greater rational good.

Kallpa's Parallel: After the Sapa Inca was killed and the empire dissolved, Kallpa faced his final choice: to fight for a new "god" (the Spanish, Choice 3), to die for the dead ideal (Choice 1), or to fight for his living family and Ayllu (Choice 2). He, too, discards abstract loyalty and chooses a new, tangible form of allegiance: the survival of his loved ones. The arc of the two characters parallels each other

beautifully, representing how loyalty shifts from an abstract, corrupted state/empire to concrete, personal responsibility and survival when that system they were taught to trust fails spectacularly.



The character of Kallpa is primarily informed by *An Inca Account of the Conquest of Peru* (Titu Cusi Yupanqui, ca. 1570), the only known first-person narrative by an Inca royal descendant, and corroborated by Pedro Cieza de León's *Crónica del Perú* (1553). These sources provide direct testimony on the Andean principles of *ayllu*, *ayni*, and *mit'a*, the catastrophic impact of epidemic disease and dynastic civil war, and the lived experiences of indigenous people facing conquest—ranging from resistance in Vilcabamba to forced labor in mines and coerced collaboration under the *encomienda* system.

Character Analysis: Guani, The Taíno Agriculturalist

Guani's positioning does share some conceptual similarities with Popoca, as both hold integral religious roles in their societies. However, the big differences in gender, culture, and the nature of the conquest come to a sharply different set of choices. Guani's arc is defined by the defilement of sacred balance and the agony of forced motherhood.

I. Dual Roles: Priestess and Elite Artisan

Guani was of high status in Taíno society as a sister of the Cacique (Chief) and a master agriculturalist:

Her profession was to transform poisonous Yuca (manioc) into life-sustaining Casabe bread. Of course, this was no cookery; it was a sacred technology—the art of turning death (toxin) into life, or food.

Core Belief (Atabey): Her belief in Atabey or Earth Mother/Goddess of Fertility went hand in hand with her role as a food creator. She believes in cosmic balance and reciprocity; thus, Ayni-the Earth provides the food, and humans maintain the balance.

The Original Sin: It was upon this belief in reciprocity that her initial welcome of the Spanish with food had been premised. She was an elite who expected foreign visitors to act in concert with the universal law of exchange. The Spanish saw only gold, however, and the Taíno social order immediately and violently collapsed—an event symbolized by her brother's hanging.

II. The Scars: Defilement and Betrayal

Guani's trauma is strongly personal, making her crisis sharply different from Popoca's philosophical disillusionment:

The Mark of Invasion: Her sexual violation by the Encomendero and the birth of her mixed-race son, Mateo, become a physical manifestation of the violence of the conquest that cannot be denied.

The Rational Hatred: The hatred towards Mateo is rationalized because he carries in his blood the very same system that hanged her brother and oppressed her people. Mateo is a living scar of that invasion, an unavoidable one. The decision to abandon him, as seen in two out of the three possible outcomes, was consistent with history and psychology.

III. The Collapse of Religious Faith

In fact, Guani's faith did not immediately disappear but eroded based on the perverse logic of the plague. The final test of her religious crisis reached its culmination when her beloved, pure Taíno son, Anani, who represented her glorious past, fell gravely ill, while the boy she hated, Mateo, miraculously recovered.

Denial of Balance: This event constituted the definitive denial of her religious faith. Why would Atabey, the goddess of life and balance, spare the "polluted" child of the invader while sacrificing the pure representative of her Taíno heritage? Being a beneficiary of the religious structure herself, this ultimate contradiction tore her belief in the justice and logic of her gods to pieces.

IV. Historical Fates and Final Choices

The three options reflect the grim realities facing the survivors of Taíno genocide.

Choice 1: Flight to the Mountains (The Vain Escape)

Historical Basis: Throughout the Caribbean, large groups of Taíno survivors fled Spanish slavery by escaping deep within mountainous regions, such as the Baboruco mountain range.

The Tragic Irony: This represents a last attempt to achieve geographical and religious purity. And yet, the disease followed them. The death of Anani in the mountains, along with other fleeing Taíno, seals the fact that religious faith alone cannot defeat biological warfare. This is indeed the real loss of faith.

Choice 2: Assimilation (The Mother's Sacrifice)

Historical Basis: A painful survival path for many Indigenous women.

The Heartbreaking Acceptance: Her cherished son dies, while the "shameful" mixed-race son survives. Though she initially hates Mateo as the product of sexual violence, she accepts him as her last remaining child. She sees that her gods cannot help.

New Faith: Her only belief now is motherhood and survival for her son. She agrees to be baptized and to adapt, and the task of rearing Mateo becomes the only other apparent purpose in life, now a tragic, self-sacrificing faith before annihilation.

Option 3: Sailing into the Unknown-The Cursed Heritage
Historical Basis: Although less common, the flight of some Taíno by canoe to islands such as Puerto Rico or Cuba finds historical attestation. Her status as the sister of the Cacique makes such an escape plausible. **The Fatalistic End:** She tries to save her

sacred craft by bringing it to a new land. However, she finally carries the curse of disease with her. Landing on the shores of the Caribs-traditional enemies-and finding them also diseased emphasizes a fatalistic tragedy: her cultural heritage, purposed to bring life to those around her, now travels with the seeds of destruction, showing an awesome, imponderable balance at work.

Character Comparison: Guani and Mikasa Ackerman

Conceptually, Guani's character arc draws inspiration from Mikasa Ackerman's in Attack on Titan. The essential parallel between the two characters is that both define themselves with profound trauma and foster an absolute protective instinct that is eventually shattered by some sort of crisis involving the very person they vowed to protect.

I. Trauma and the Anchor of Protection

Both Guani and Mikasa derive from devastating personal trauma, which fixed one single, absolute focus upon which their loyalty and survival instinct are predicated:

Guani's Trauma: She experienced multiple traumas: sexual violence, the hanging of her brother, and swift collapse of her culture. Her mixed-race son, Mateo, became a living symbol of this trauma and the nation's shame. Her anchor was her purely Taíno son, Anani.

Mikasa's trauma includes: At nine years old, she saw her parents killed and herself almost being killed. She was then saved by Eren Yeager, from whom she had formed an anchor, which represented her only home and safety.

II. The Crisis: The Collapse of the Anchor

When the reality of their loved ones fundamentally contradicts that survival mechanism, the collapse of faith and sanity occurs:

Guani's Crisis: The moment of her ultimate disillusionment occurred when her cherished, purely Taíno son, Anani, was dying from disease, while the child she hated—Mateo, the product of violation—survived. She was forced to confront a reality where her values and the divine order were completely inverted.

Mikasa's crisis came in the realization that Eren, the person she swore to protect above all others, had transformed into the destroyer of the world-the very one she should eliminate if she were to save humanity.

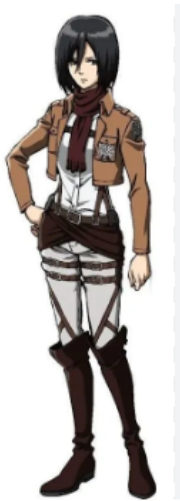
In each case, the crisis is focused on the threat or betrayal regarding someone that they loved most.

III. The Painful Choice (Choice 2)

Both are ultimately compelled into a single painful act that uproots them from their assumed emotional base and replaces it with a counteractive new reality:

Guani's Choice 2 (Assimilation): Anani dies, but Mateo lives. Guani makes the tortured decision to accept and preserve the child she essentially hates because of his heritage and the circumstances of his birth. This mothering becomes her new, horrific faith. In a psychological sense, Mateo is the "new Anani"—the new, imperfect, contradictory anchor of her existence. She takes on the shame and assimilation required to sustain him.

Mikasa's Choice: She had to make the ultimate choice to personally kill Eren, the only person she had ever loved and sworn to protect. This final, painful act was the only way to save the world, marking a brutal shift from absolute personal loyalty to rational, existential responsibility. Such a decision is both profoundly tragic: the abandonment of one form of love/loyalty to commit to a more painful, complex, or contradictory form of survival.



The character of Guani is primarily informed by Bartolomé de las Casas' *A Short Account of the Destruction of the Indies* (1552), an eyewitness testimony to the genocide of the Taíno people. Corroborated by modern ethnography (Keegan, 2007), the narrative reflects the Taíno worldview centered on Atabey and Zemí, the trauma of encomienda slavery and sexual violence, the demographic collapse from epidemic disease, and the impossible choices faced by survivors—flight to the mountains, forced conversion, or perilous escape to the Lesser Antilles.

Character Analysis: B'alam, The Maya Merchant

B'alam is conceived of as a thorough pragmatist whose driving interest is a foil to the profound religious and communitarian crises of the previous characters. He pays lip service to the Maya God of Merchants, Ek' Chuah-whose guiding principle is "never make a losing deal"-but his real faith is in profit and self-interest.

I. The Pragmatic Merchant (Contrasting Role)

Role Differentiation: B'alam is set apart on purpose from the previous protagonists. Whereas they have been identified through spiritual roles, such as Popoca the artisan and Guani the priestess/farmer, or social contracts like Kallpa the highlander, B'alam is defined by commerce alone.

Belief System: Although he acknowledges Ek' Chuah, his true creed is material gain. He makes use of his knowledge about the Maya city-states, their various gods, and political feuds as mere market intelligence.

He skillfully navigates the hostile territories of the Xiu (the new elite) and Cocom (the old rulers). He sells them not only cocoa beans and wax but the illusion of ideological loyalty by celebrating their respective gods, Kukulcan and Chaac, hoping to secure better deals. He thinks about all ideology-even his own-as a commodity.

Conquest as Business: Unlike the others, who view the Spanish invasion as God's judgment or disaster, B'alam treats it as a "new player" or a hostile "market takeover"-a challenge requiring immediate high-stakes investment. His design is intended to subvert the context of suffering by looking at it through a purely transactional frame.

II. Historical Corroboration and Motivations

The choices made by B'alam are grounded in the complex political reality of the Post-Classic Yucatán Maya, especially in the rivalries between the Xiu and Cocom factions, extended into the early colonial era.

Choice 1: Exploiting the Competition (Investing in the Winner)

Historical Basis: This answer is most likely to be correct because, spurred by an ancient grudge against the Cocomic lineage, the Tutul Xiu did indeed ally with the Spanish conquistadors. This was a key factor in the rapid conquest of the Yucatán since the Spanish naturally took full advantage of the existing political

fragmentation. A small number of indigenous individuals benefited from early collaboration, gaining either power or trade monopolies.

B'alam's Rationale: His decision is a purely rational investment. He bets on the Xiu-Spanish alliance because they possess the superior "assets" needed (steel, horses, artillery) to win the "market war." He is ready to sell his most valuable intelligence-trade routes, location of cenotes-to become the chief supplier and monopolist in the new capital Mérida.

Conclusion: A case of the classic "collaboration for profit" at the expense of loyalty.

Option 2: Jungle Resistance or The Failed Investment

This is based on historical records of the resistance led by the Cocom faction, which saw the alliance with the Xiu as unforgivable treason. The Maya did use their superior knowledge of the jungle, the cenotes (sinkholes/water sources), and logistics in order to hold out for years.

B'alam's Reasoning: This is a high-risk investment based on his belief that the Spanish will prove unsustainable-a poor market player-and that the local, traditional market will prevail. His defeat proves his core flaw: his pragmatism underestimated the resilience of Xiu-Cocom hatred and the ruthlessness of the Spanish military. The bad ending in this story perfectly epitomizes how a shrewd businessman made a fatally bad investment.

Option 3: Religious Fusion - The Betrayed Cultural Broker

Historical Basis: This is powerfully supported by the actions of Fray Diego de Landa, who was initially eager to understand and record Maya culture but later became paranoid about "backsliding." The climax is the 1562 Auto de Fe in Maní where Landa burned countless Maya codices and subjected many nobles (including Xiu allies) to torture. Some Maya did attempt to feign conversion or act as cultural intermediaries for gain.

B'alam's Motivation: He views the friars as the long-term power structure-the new ideological gatekeepers. He tries to be an indispensable cultural broker by playing off of his knowledge of the "old gods" as a way to curry favor. **The Irony:** The irony is devastating: the ultimate pragmatist who views religion as merely a tool is destroyed by ultimate religious fanaticism. His asset—his specialized knowledge of the Maya religion—becomes the direct cause of his torture and the destruction of the very cultural records he used for trade.

Character Comparison: B'alam and Kenny Ackerman

For B'alam, the character concept is based on Kenny Ackerman. The basic common point in them is that extreme pragmatism is the only true faith. Both are cynical actors who expertly use larger ideological systems while being internally contemptuous of structures they serve.

I. Central Doctrine: The Greatest Happiness Principle

The actions of both B'alam and Kenny are motivated by utilitarian calculation:

B'alam: His creed is the one at the heart of the Merchant God, Ek' Chuah: "Never make a losing deal." He makes vows and offers praise to gods publicly to facilitate sales, but his actual belief rests only in profit.

Kenny Ackerman (The Power Broker): Although he fundamentally despised the monarchy, his initial subjugation by their power-Uri Reiss led him to become the Crown's "loyal dog." Kenny's loyalty was mixed: part personal fascination with Uri, and part utilitarianism driven by the desire to get close enough to seize the Founding Titan's power.

The motivation lies within their different ultimate goals, whereby B'alam wants to get the highest amount of profit possible and Kenny wants to gain the Founding Titan's power. Their morality is thin; whatever it takes, they will commit an act in order to achieve their goals.

II. Pragmatism as the Basis of Strategic Choices

B'alam's three choices reflect the different high-stakes strategies Kenny pursued in order to gain access to, or influence, the power structure:

Choice 1: Competing on Rivalry (Investing in the Winner)

This parallels Kenny's decision to ally with Rod Reiss, serving as the monarchy's violent enforcer. It is a power transaction: both align themselves with the perceived central authority-the Spanish/the Crown-as the fastest way to gain the highest "asset"-monopoly/Founding Titan power.

Option 2: Jungle Resistance (The Lost Investment)

This parallels Kenny's last effort against Levi for the capture of Eren. It is a decision to defend one's own established power base-or small circle-against an overwhelming and irreversible trend. To pragmatic players, this defiance would be an ill-placed investment in a lost cause doomed to fail.

Choice 3: Religious Fusion Cultural Broker

This corresponds to Kenny's strategy of building his own elite squad within the Central Military Police. Both establish themselves as internal brokers within the larger body, using specialized knowledge-of Maya customs/of the underground-to manipulate the system and secure a profitable or survivalist niche. B'alam deals in religious knowledge; Kenny deals in violence and intelligence. In sum, both B'alam and Kenny are prime examples of moral nihilists whose actions are driven by the highest rational calculation of power and self-interest, making their final, tragic demises at the hands of irrational forces all the more ironic.



The character of B'alam is primarily informed by *The Book of Chilam Balam of Chumayel*, a post-conquest Maya manuscript that preserves indigenous prophecies, historical memory, and political analysis of the Spanish invasion. Corroborated by modern scholarship (Clendinnen, 1988), the narrative reflects the deep enmity between the Xiu and Cocom lineages, the apocalyptic significance of K'atun 13 Ajaw, and the strategic calculations of Maya elites—whether to collaborate, resist, or mediate—as they navigated the collapse of their world and the rise of colonial rule.

The BGM from the Film: "The Last of the Mohicans" (1992)

Film description: It is set in 1757 during the French and Indian War. It tells of Hawkeye, a hunter brought up by the Mohican tribe, attempting to protect Cora, a British colonel's daughter, from the relentless pursuit of Magua, a vengeful Huron warrior.

The Reason I chose it as BGM

The BGM here is from The Last of the Mohicans.

Although the movie is from the 18th century and does not fit this game, which is set in the 16th century, I find its general ambiance to perfectly fit. The music strongly conveys the deep desolation of indigenous American cultures facing decline and makes extensive use of traditional Native instruments like Drums, flutes, rattles, and shakers. Thus, I find it very fitting for this Art style for the game: I primarily used lightning effects. This was done to echo the frequent lightning storms that are a common natural phenomenon in the Americas.

Beyond this, wherever possible, the art style seeks a more "ancient" or "antiquated" feel while keeping the visual effects generally consistent with the story.

Game installation: <https://github.com/MengChonL/VOICES-OF-THE-VANQUISHED/tree/main>

Data Source

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AI Guidance:

Translation

Build up the role frame to introduce the character to separate the important moments or differences with the character, to separate my text

Data Research